It was only at this point that the Liberal Democrat Leadership reacted. Referring to Ward's original Israelis/Jews-Nazis statement, Liberal Democrat Leader and Deputy Prime Minister Nick Clegg said in the House of Commons, "I am unambiguous in my condemnation of anyone, from whatever party, including my own, who uses insensitive, intemperate, provocative, and offensive language."[19] Ward was accordingly called to the House of Commons for a meeting with Deputy Prime Minister Clegg, the Liberal Democrat Party Deputy Leader, Simon Hughes, and the (then) Liberal Democrat Chief Whip, Alistair Carmichael.[20]

While the rules of the Liberal Democrat Party Constitution allowed for Ward to be subjected to an internal investigation or to have his whip withdrawn at this point, the meeting was used merely to discuss Ward's need to comment on the Israel-Palestinian conflict using language that was both "precise" and "proportionate."[21] I understand from conversations with members of the Liberal Democrat Friends of Israel that neither the issue of antisemitism nor the issue of discipline was raised at this meeting. The Liberal Democrat Leadership missed an important opportunity to publicly warn Ward about his use of antisemitic language, or if necessary, to help raise his awareness of the ways in which antisemitism can manifest itself in discourse, by engaging the Community Security Trust (CST) to work with him.

In fact, the emphasis on the need for him to be "precise" in his choice of language only seemed to feed Ward's antisemitic ways of thinking. This is evident from the statement he made immediately following the meeting:

> There is a huge operation out there, a machine almost, which is designed to protect the State of Israel from criticism. And it comes into play very, very quickly and focuses intensely on anyone who's seen to criticise the State of Israel. And so I end up looking at what happened to me, whether I should use this word, whether I should use that word—and that is winning for them.[22]

The Liberal Democrat Leadership's dismal failure to use that meeting to discipline Ward for his antisemitic comments meant that he was not restrained from making further antisemitic and otherwise offensive remarks. For instance, in November 2013 he tweeted, "[W]hat a shame there isn't a powerful well-funded Board of Deputies for #Roma," and in January 2014 he tweeted "[J]ust seen 'Twelve Years a Slave'—powerful—brutal inhumanity we still see today in places such as #Palestine."[23] In the same month he added: "[S]haron's death makes you think. The brutal, genocidal treatment of Jews must never be forgotten, but. . .the #Palestinians were not responsible."[24]

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